The One who Bleeds

“Call a halt. Call a Halt!” Numian yelled. The convoy of wagons slowly rolled to a stop, smoke puffing from the intricately carved exhausts that rose above the metal boxes like spears. Numian grabbed the lip of the opening before lifting himself onto the roof. He grabbed the exhaust, and leaned forward to get a better view. His gloves protected him from the heat of the exhaust, but he could still feel the warmth through them. Nine Wagons, varying in colour, make, and size lay lined up haphazardly. Numian could already tell, despite not being well acquainted with the vehicles, that at least two of them would have to be left behind. The area they stopped in was decent for a short break, unfortunately they were short on time. The woods provided good cover and concealment, but the elves would still eventually catch up. If they kept up with the last estimates, they had around an hour and a half before they had to run again.

Forge. This isn't going to keep working.

“Tallar! Someone get me Tallar!” He hollered, Voice straining to be heard over the rumble of the engines. The new wagons were effective, Numian couldn’t argue with that. They were faster than any horse Numian rode and had more stamina than them too. They still had their problems, mainly that they were unsuitable for any rough roads and they needed constant repairs, so Numian had to make room, which meant less soldiers.

“Numian!” A voice called out. Numian finally saw his friend step out from another one of the wagons, smoke pouring from the windows. To anyone else, the sight of a dwarf would be frightening. The smooth metal exterior, a warm glow emanating from their core, only seen from the eyes, mouth, and joints. They were fully composed of metal, with their eyes being socketed with two gems that reflected the heat inside them. Tallar wore armour painted white and blue, same colours as Numain, with a shield crossed with a hammer proudly emblazoned on the back, the icon of the Ironhearts.

“What the forge happened to your wagon?” Numian asked, voice still straining to be heard over the wagons.

“What? I can’t hear you!” The dwarf said, finger tapping his ear.

“Someone turn these forging wagons off! No need to paint a target on our backs!” Numian screamed, coughing slightly as he inhaled some of the smoke coming from the exhaust. He pounded the top of the wagon twice, and apparently the operator finally got the signal, the smoke plumes and noise slowly sputtering out. They really didn't need to keep quiet, whatever magic the elves used to track the convoy was pinpoint accurate, but the thought of having plumes of smoke above them still made Numian uncomfortable.

“Hey. Numian. You call for me?” Tallar said, now at the foot of the wagon, Rubbing his forehead.

Numian kept his eyes on the rest of the convoy, watching as soldiers and civilians alike helped each other. “We can’t keep doing this. The elves will catch us by nightfall, maybe earlier if we keep this up.”

“Sir!” a rough voice cut through the wind

Numian reflexively caught the flask, the standard leatherskin that was issued to all soldiers.

“Thanks, Ryshar. Get the rest of the men together. Get the boys together and tend to any wounds. We have 90 minutes before the silver eared fools catch up to us.” Numian downed the water quickly, before throwing the leatherskin back to the older lieutenant

“Aye sir” the aged soldier replied, catching the leatherskin before folding it and storing it in his officer's coat. “You look like scrap iron sir, you ought to take a break sometime”

“I will, I will.” Numian replied. Ryshar was the only one with the leather to criticise him so plainly, and also the one of the only ones he respected enough to listen to.

“Sorry,” Numian said, turning back to Tallar. “Anyways we need a new plan.”

Tallar blew steam through his nostrils, twin jets shooting out in anger. “Forge, this is a mess” he cursed, kicking the dirt in front of him. “The Ironfather will never admit it, but he can’t die here. The alliance of metals is already tenuous and without him to unite them, we’ll be at each other's necks before the hammer strikes steel. Those damned knife ears, this was coordinated.”

“Don’t talk politics to me, Tallar.” Numian said, hopping down from the carriage roof, landing softly on the dirt next to the dwarf, before walking down the row of wagons “I’m the soldier, you're the advisor. We could use some forging advice right about now.”

“Alright, Alright” Tallar responded, following Numian. “If we can make a distraction, or lead the elves away, we could probably make it to any one of the neighbouring keeps.”

An older dwarf, with redder, more molten skin approached the two of them. “Tallar” he said, voice as thick as molten metal, deep and slow. The dwarf said something to Tallar in their native tongue. Over 21 years of living with the dwarves, his entire life and he still couldn’t understand a thing. The language was rough, guttural and sounded more like rocks and metal hitting each other than anything decipherable.

Tallar nodded, and the older dwarf wandered away, attending to the wagons and the other survivors. “Numian,” He said, voice heavy with urgency, before pausing and staring directly at the young man. “The Ironfather needs to see you.”

“Yeah, Yeah-” Numian started, before being cut off as Tallar grabbed him by the shoulders.

“Numian!” He shouted quietly, shaking the young man slightly. “Just because you're favoured by Danadros, and are the Captain general of the Royal Guard, Doesn't mean you get to do whatever you want!”

Numian planted his hands on the leather portions of Tallars armour, anywhere else would have burned him, before gently pushing him backwards. “I’m trying to save us, Tallar.” Numian said softly, before tapping the insignia on his left breast, the sigil of the Ironhearts, with a sword instead of a hammer. “This symbol is everything to me, Tallar. I’m sworn to

protect the Ironfather, and my honour prevents me from putting trivial matters before saving lives."

"There might not be a next time, Numian!" Tallar said, more emotion leaking into his normally jovial voice. "Just talk to the Ironfather for Davrians sake man!"

"Ok, Ok" Numian said, turning to the Ironfather's carriage. "I'll be quick. After that we need to talk about what to do next." We're at the end of our bellows, Tallar."

"Just go!" Tallar insisted, Palms pushing Numian towards the carriage.

Numian approached the carriage, Black with the banners of the Ironhearts proudly emblazoned, now dirty with dirt and soot from the messy getaway. Two of his men stood at the doors to the carriage, at rest but vigilant.

"Sir!" they said in unison, crossing their right arm to their chest in salute.

"At ease, Men" He said, returning the salute. "I have enough pressure with the damned elves breathing down my back"

"If you say so sir," The men relaxed their postures and their expressions softened, their concern and fear hidden under false, but believable grins.

"Go get some food from whoever is quartermaster this week. Tell Ryshar to wait here for me" Numian said, before pulling open the heavy iron door of the carriage.

The inside was dark, only lit by the embers of the still smouldering coals. The compartment was separated in two with a curtain, the side numain was on had the compartment for carrying fuel and the two doors.

"Captain general." a measured and clipped voice said, before opening the dividing curtain, revealing another dwarf, with red garbs rather than the standard blue and white of the Steelhearts. "He's lucid right now, but shout for me if anything happens. I'll give you two some privacy."

"Thanks, Tuscan." Numian nodded to the physician, who slid past Numian in the cramped wagon before exiting the wagon.

Numian pulled the curtain back, before sliding in the other portion.

The Ironfather was an imposing figure, even resting on a reclined chair. He towered over any man or dwarf alike, standing over 9 feet tall. Even sitting, the Ironfather was eye level with Numian. His skin was cracked and molten, revealing veins of metal coursing through his body. He lit up the entire room with a soft orange glow, and cast shadows as his head turned to regard Numian.

"Thank the forge" The Ironfather said. "I was wondering if you died during the ambush"

“I’m ok, my lord” Numian said, before kneeling in front of the old ruler.

“Stop with the customaries, Son of Iron” The Ironfather said, waving his arm “Your Captain General for a reason”

“Very well, Danadros” Numian said, taking a seat on a stool beside the old dwarf, Wlping his brow with his sleeve. Even in his weakened state, The Ironfather was as hot as a campfire, and being so close caused Numian to sweat. He didn't complain at all despite the discomfort, he respected the man too much to complain about such a trivial matter. “How are your wounds?”

The Ironfather moved his hand from his chest, revealing an onyx black dagger embedded right next to where his heart would be, lines of black causing the metal around the wound to cool and rust, like some sort of disease of metal”.

“Forging Slag!” Numian exclaimed, eyes widening in surprise. “How are you still awake?”

“The dwarven body is not as weak as that of man, no offence” Danadros explained, finger tracing the wound, charred and rusted. “My secondary heart is still pumping, but I feel myself getting weaker. I don’t usually ask for much, Numian, but please, keep the others alive. If I die, promise me you will lead the rest to safety.”

“Yes sir” Numian swallowed.

You're the one who needs to live
“The alliance of metals is already tenuous and without him to unite them, we’ll be at each other's necks before the hammer strikes steel.”

The words echoed in his mind as he clasped hands with the old dwarf, promising to get them to safety.

“I’m sorry to say, Danadros, but we’re in quite the slagging mess. Last time we saw them, I think we were outnumbered 2-1 and they had nobody to protect too. I need some advice.” Numian said, frustration evident in his tone.

“Ah, yes. How to escape a faster, better equipped enemy. When I was younger, we had a manoeuvre, based on a particular type of animal. Me and your fa-” The Ironfather began to cough and covered his mouth with his other hand.

“Wait, how are you coughing?” Numian asked. He had never seen another dwarf actually cough before, only fake coughing or laughing.

“It must be the wound.” The Ironfather said quickly, “Anyways, when a skink is frightened, it runs away, but it also cuts off its own tail. While the predator is preoccupied with the distraction, the skink can sneak away and live another day.”

“Where is the nobility in that?” Numian asked, frowning. “I’m not going to condemn anybody to death just because I want to live.”

“There's more to life than nobility, Numian. A life is priceless, so sacrificing one priceless thing to keep 50 priceless things is a worthy action.”

“No.” Numian said, shaking his head. “What if I surrender?” I’ll take my men and let you escape separately, then surrender. At least then nobody else dies.”

“Hah.” Danadros laughed, wincing as the action caused the blade to shift slightly. “Surrendering to elves. You’d be more likely to get visited by Davrian himself.”

“I’m tired, Numian. I trust you’ll get us out of this mess.” Danadros said, laying his free arm on Numians shoulder. “You're the best of us for a reason, Son of Iron. Your heart is stronger than diamond, and your determination is brighter than any dwarf's core.”

“Thank you, Ironfather. I-” Numian said, flustered by the praise, before being cut off

“Take my dagger, Son of Iron” Danadros said, Pushing the hilt of the dagger into Numians hand. “May the Ancestral forge bless you well, Numian”

“Are you sure?” Numian asked, eyes wide at the weapon. The blade was intricately carved, etched with dwarven runes, which Numian assumed proclaimed its ownership to the Ironheart’s dynasty. As he watched, The runes shifted and glowed, before settling in a similar pattern, slightly different but Numian couldn’t read the script, and was unable to guess what it might say.

“Yes, treat it well Numian.” Dandaros said, handing Numian a wrist sheath.

“What does it say?” Numian asked, putting the sheath on his wrist and securing the blade.

“Nothing important right now.” The Ironfather said to Numian. “Time runs short, Numian. May the forge guide you, Son of Iron.”

“Very well.” Numian said, turning and leaving the carriage, understanding that the conversation was over.

As Numian stepped out of the carriage, he shaded his eyes as they adjusted from the glow of the wagon to the glare of the sun

“Tuscan. What do you know about the wound?” Numian asked, assessing the readiness of the caravan to get moving again. “Dandros didn’t tell me much, but that wound did not look natural. Magic involved somehow?”

“Yes.” The Physician responded, tone measured but with a slight hint of frustration. “I’ve never seen such a wound in my entire career, whatever this was, its not physical in malady,

The runecasters will know more, if you can get us to safety.” The Dwarf stared critically at Numian, as if dissecting his responses.

“I will.” Numian said, staring straight at the horizon, not adding anything else.

Tuscan didn't push farther, apparently satisfied with the answer.

Ryshar came jogging up to Numian, and gave a quick salute.
“Sir, Physician.” He said, greeting the two. “You called for me, Numian?”

“Yeah.” Numian responded, shaking himself out of contemplation. “How ready are we to leave?”

“We’re ready to make haste at a moment's notice.” Ryshar explained. “The boys can keep going for a few more hours, but I suggest we make time to rest up.”

“Yeah, sure.” Numian replied, leaning close to Ryshar. “Cram everyone who isn't a soldier into as little wagons as possible. Tell Tallar to get them to the closest keep. We take the rest of the wagons and waste as much time as possible. “

“Sir?” Ryshar said, half asking half stating “Are you sure this is a good idea? I have no problems risking my life, but what if we mess up?”

“We won’t.” Numian said, “We’ll die trying if we need to, but that way we’ll buy as much time as possible. Also, we can always surrender. At least that way, we’ll all live.”

“Whatever you say, Numian” Ryshar said, “We trust you.”

Numian nodded to Ryshar, and the older officer ran off to start the preparations.

“You're a fool, you know?”

Numian turned to look at Tuscan, who was shaking his head. “What I learned on the battlefield was that chivalry is the first thing to die. You're going to all die, you know?”

Numian stiffened at the blatant advice. “I’ll find a way” he said, swallowing as he did so.

As the last of the wagons were loaded, they separated into two columns. The first, which had 4 carriages, carried his men and a false suite of supplies. The last two carriages, were loaded to the brim with people and dwarves. As the two parties left in different directions, Numian stood atop one of the roofs.

“Numian!” A voice rang out. Numian spotted the form of Tallar, leaning out of one of the carriage windows.

“Strike the Hammer, Shape the fate” Tallar said, Crossing his right arm to his chest in salute. Numian returned the gesture.

I guess we do have to sacrifice someone after all. Ourselves. At least this way we live with honour.

Numian sat in one of the wagons, watching the forest speed by him through the window. He sat with 5 other soldiers, including Ryshar.

“I don’t know about this sir.” one of the younger soldiers said to Numian, shifting uncomfortably in his seat. “What are we going to do when they finally catch up?”

Ryshar spoke up before Numian could respond. “Son, the Captain General is smarter than he looks.” Ryshar took a cigarette from his breast pocket and offered one to the kid, who shook his head. He put the cigarette between his teeth and took a lighter from the same pocket, lighting the cigarette before continuing. “He’ll get us out of this mess if it's the last thing he does.”

“Yeah.” another one of the soldiers said, absentmindedly fidgeting with a coin. “He’s saved old Ryshar’s life a dozen times.”

All the soldiers, including the younger man, snickered at the jab.

“Don’t make me remind you of the time you tried to use one of those rifles and shot yourself in the foot.”

The laughter grew into a roar, and the soldier that originally threw the insult grew red faced and rubbed his foot.

“It wasn’t my fault those forging weapons are so complicated to operate” he muttered. “It’ll take the forgemasters a few more months before I’ll even think about picking one of those up again.”

Numian nodded at the insight. The elvish attackers used rifles, which proved very effective at eliminating targets from range. Numian shivered, remembering the details of the first ambush. A well travelled route, which they had taken many times before. Elvish assassins waiting in the trees, rifles picking off people in the windows. Numian had spotted the trap before they were fully in it, and was able to break through by travelling at max speed on the wagons. They had lost only a few soldiers, but the elves kept coming. Every 90 minutes, Numian assumed that's how long it took for their magic to either locate or teleport to them, the elves would lay in wait and try to stop the convoy. The charade had gone on for 4 hours, before they finally had a plan. They could stand their ground, now that they had nobody to defend. Hopefully Danadros and the others got to safety, and he and his men would follow suit if everything went according to plan.

“Ryshar.” Numian said, in a serious tone, looking into the man's eyes.

“Eh?” The older man said, cupping his ear so he could hear over the laughter in the carriage. “You figured out some spectacular plan?”

“Something like that.” Numian responded “Stop the carriages near the ravine which is close to the copperarm mountain. We stand as one, against the storm.”

“Aye sir.” Ryshar responded, flicking his cigarette out the window, and standing up to give the signal. He reached his hand out the window, and knocked on the door that made up the drivers compartment. The wagons had no way of communicating with the driver, so simple knocks had to be used. The wagon turned left at the next intersection, and soon they arrived at a narrow ravine. The wagon sounded its horn twice, and slowly the caravan rolled to a stop. His soldiers, eighteen in total, he had lost a few to the constant ambushes, lined up into rows of six, and columns of three. Each and every one of them had their faces in a mask of determination, no matter how scared they felt on the inside. Even the younger man, that had reservations earlier seemed convinced that he would get them out of this. Ryshar walked up next to him, eyes scanning the soldiers.

“What's the plan?” Ryshar asked, taking another cigarette from his bag, and lighting it. He took a long drag from it, and puffed out 3 rings of smoke. “It better be a damn good plan, I don’t want to die here.”

Numian ignored the jab, feeling the weight of responsibility on his shoulders. He’d commanded more men at worse odds, right? “We’ll put the carriages parallel to the ravine, making a half circle. We’ll use them as cover and make a kill corridor. If they can’t shoot down at us, they’ll have to approach one on one. We’ll have spearmen in the back and shields in the front.”

“Good plan.” Ryshar admitted. “I’ll get started.”

Numian didn’t get any more arguments from Ryshar. Once the man was confident in a plan, he would do everything in his power to execute it.

I’ve been blessed by Darvian himself, thank god for that man.

Numian watches as his soldiers line up the wagons, making a crescent shape, the open side facing the ravine, with a small opening in the middle, just big enough for two shields to block. The entire project took until nightfall, and eventually all the men sat in the crescent, quietly eating their rations. No fires were lit, that would be too suspicious. Despite the rather uncomfortable atmosphere, his men seemed to be in good spirits. He heard quiet conversations, and even some laughter from them. Despite the high spirits, Numian couldn’t shake the sense of unease building inside him. He thumbed the clip that held the newly gifted dagger on his wrist, clicking it in place, then popping it back out. Click, pop, click, pop, click pop. He watches the line of trees ahead of the convoy, staring intently, scanning for any movement.

100 feet of empty ground, it will take them 15 seconds to cross the outcropping before engaging us. Bows will be useless. Too long to draw.

“Ryshar” he called, eyes still scanning the forest, hands fidgeting with his dagger. “Don’t bother with archers. Its too close and there isn’t enough time to draw strings and aim.”

“Aye sir.” Ryshar replied, nodding to the four bowmen that they had. “Don’t bother with the bows. Use your shortswords if possible though.”

Numian turned to Ryshar, “It feels too quiet right now.” He said. “Somethings up”

Ryshar grimaced, looking past Numian and into the ring of trees. “Well, you were right.”

Numian spun around, cursing as he saw what lay in the trees “As soon as I looked away,” he cursed. “They’re here”

The trees shook as multiple brown cloaked figures jumped from the trees, and made for Numian and his men. His men dutifully and efficiently got into formation, two men with large tower shields positioning them on the only entrance to their bubble of protection. The few seconds spent waiting felt like hours. Numians stomach turned, and the sinking feeling he felt earlier cut through his adrenaline. He waited alongside his men, weapons ready and waiting.

Somethings wrong

Numian cursed under his breath. “They should be upon us already” He whispered to himself, sword in a half-ready position.

“I’ll check it out,” Ryshar muttered, and before Numian could protest, he quickly scaled the sides of one of the wagons despite his aged body, and looked past the barricade. Ryshar cursed and he scrambled down as a bullet flew where his head was “They’re making some sort of spell circle around us. We’re sitting ducks